Given Daulet Singh's mindset and the stance taken by him against Army HQ's advice to abandon Chushul, the decision to abruptly withdraw 114 Brigade on the night of 19 November is extremely perplexing. For all the noise being created in the Western Sector, if the two Jammu & Kashmir Militia wings were to be excluded, the total number of troops that had actually engaged the Chinese were roughly equivalent to a single infantry battalion: one company of 5 Jat at DBO, Qara Qash and Galwan; one company of 1/8 GR at Srijap and Yula; one company of 13 Kumaon at Rezang-la and one more company of 1/8 GR deployed at Gurung Hill.

Raina had not shown himself to be an imaginative commander, nevertheless the men under his command had not shown any signs of abandoning their defences. Not only had the Chinese until then scrupulously not crossed the claim line in any of the sectors in Ladakh (including Demchok), even on the evening of 18 November, they had not occupied Gurung Hill after the Gorkhas had pulled out. The only person who could have taken the decision and who clearly outranked Daulet was Thapar. In that case, the order issued by Army HQ to Western Command to fall back from Chushul would be the last operational order issued by Thapar before his resignation came into effect.

Ironically, a few years later, Kaul was to say of the fighting in Ladakh: 'What happened to us in Ladakh—where our debacle was as great in magnitude as in NEFA? As a matter of fact neither the Chushul village nor the airfield were even attacked nor did any battle take place there, though green pictures of fighting in the battle of Chushul have been painted to give the impression that Ladakh (as opposed to NEFA) put up a stout resistance. The saving grace in Ladakh was that Chushul, not being in the claim line, remained intact (because it was never attacked).'

Raina was awarded a Maha Vir Chakra, the country's second highest award for bravery, an award that from any point of view defied logic. Majors Dhan Singh Thapa and Shaitan Singh were given Param Vir Chakras, both perhaps eventually justified, but they were given at a time when there were absolutely no details available about the fighting either at Srijap or at Rezang-la. In the long run this would have repercussions of its own, for exaggerated accounts of the battle were written to justify the awards. There is no taking away from the incredible bravery of 1/8 GR at Srijap or that of 13 Kumaon where 114 men died, each man facing the Chinese until he was killed. Yet, flip through any account of the battle today